acquire membership in the legislative council and later, in the executive council. In 1984, a CIA report said growing political polarisation in Fiji was Mara's main hurdle and that Indian membership in his Alliance Party had dwindled since 1970, with ethnic Indians drifting to the National Federation Party of Fiji which was the main opposition political front. The CIA observed that constitutional safeguards enacted during the British colonial period to protect the Fijians from being overwhelmed by the more aggressive Indians contributed to Indian resentment and had created an unbridgeable gap between the two races. Despite the discrimination, Indians dominated business and the professional sphere in Fiji. They prevailed in institutions of higher learning in spite of government decreed advantages for Fijians, such as scholarships and lower entrance requirements. CIA reports observed:

The Indians seem resigned to second class political status as long as they can prosper economically. Indians, for example, make up the majority of graduates of the University of the South Pacific in Fiji and almost the entire faculty and student body of its medical school.

Some agents of the R&AW suspected that Ratu Mara had been recruited by the USA administration to check Soviet influence in the South Pacific. He had barred the entry of Soviet ships in Fiji and even turned down Moscow's request to open an embassy in Suva.

'Mara was not an easy man to deal with. He warmly supported the US activities in Fiji's waters and had strong contempt for India and the Soviets. He never openly spoke about India but intelligence inputs during 1984-85 made it clear that the